alert, streetlights along the border were extinguished, followed by the termination of underground and S-Bahn services.

As this was happening, troops blocked the windows of apartments on the border with corrugated iron, as 20,000 armed men fanned the length of more than 160 kilometres to halt all traffic from East to West. Erich Mielke was the first to inspect roadblocks and barriers, followed by Defence Minister Heinz Hoffmann, who remembered Honecker arriving to shake hands and pat a few backs. ‘He spoke not only to me and other high-ranking officers but, as is his habit, also to the other ranks on the spot and explained to them why we had to take these measures.’11 ‘For Honecker, this was probably his masterpiece in dealing with the armed forces,’ said Helmut Müller, then an FDJ functionary. ‘He was in charge and all eyes were on him.’12 In the last stretch, as sharp coils of barbed wire were spread out across a few remaining road junctions, Honecker returned to police headquarters, retiring to his hideaway on the second floor. At 04.00, before most Berliners were awake, he heard RIAS radio’s first reports that GDR police had shut off sectors of the border and, at the same time, traffic between the two parts of Berlin had ground to a halt.13As the darkness lightened, Hoffman confirmed the provisional border was fully sealed by 06.00. Glancing at his watch, Honecker said proudly, ‘now we can go,’ and released his staff. ‘Operation Rose’ had passed without incident. To celebrate, Honecker, Hoffmann and Mielke raised balloons of cognac to their achievement, the atmosphere was festive. ‘That morning,’ Honecker remembered, ‘Comrade Ulbricht made the first inspection tour at the border. The orders had been precisely implemented. Our leaders had shown great organisational skill. Everything went exactly according to plan. Peace in Europe was saved, and the basis for the great ascent of our GDR was established.’14

Within just five hours, Berlin – one of the most famous cities in the world – had been sealed tight.